

Postsecondary Education Support and Earning Outcomes through Participation in Vocational Rehabilitation Services

By Stormy Miller Sabia, Ed.D. & Mark Tucker, Ph.D., CRC

INTRODUCTION

Between individuals with and without disabilities, there are significant disparities in labor force participation, employment rates, and earnings. For people with disabilities who are employed, there is little opportunity for career advancement (Siperstein, Parker, & Drascher, 2013). According to the Kessler Foundation and University of New Hampshire Institute on Disability, 34.7% of people with disabilities were employed in 2019; in contrast, the employment-population ratio was 74.6% for persons without disabilities (Research on Disability, 2019).

For youth with intellectual disability (ID), there is even greater disparity in education and employment outcomes. Youth with ID are less likely to have postsecondary education or competitive employment goals in their transition plans and have lower rates of employment and postsecondary education participation than youth with other disabilities (Grigal, Hart, & Migliore, 2011; Grigal, Migliore, & Hart, 2014). Only 30% of youth with ID go on to any type of postsecondary education after high school (Grigal, Hart, & Migliore 2011), and 81% of people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) are served in segregated non-work settings (Butterworth et al., 2012).

PURPOSE

The purpose of this study was to assess the provision of college and university training by vocational rehabilitation (VR) agencies and examine the associations between certificate or degree completion and weekly earnings among individuals with IDD served by the federal-state VR system. VR is a federal-state resource that can provide services and supports to individuals with disabilities in order to maximize the likelihood of obtaining and retaining employment. One service that VR can provide funds for is college and university training. Although only a small percentage of individuals with IDD have received college support from VR, there is increasing interest in postsecondary

education as a means to improve employment outcomes for individuals with IDD.

METHODS

Four research questions were investigated through a quantitative methodological approach using a series of extant data files from the U.S. Department of Education spanning federal fiscal years 2006 through 2016. Some questions were based upon data from a single fiscal year, while other questions employed data from several fiscal years.

The following four research questions were investigated:

RQ1: Was there a significant difference in mean weekly earnings at case closure between individuals with IDD in California who advanced to postsecondary certificate or degree completion while their rehabilitation case was open and individuals with IDD who did not advance to postsecondary certificate or degree completion?

RQ2: Were there any significant differences in mean weekly earnings at case closure between individuals with four different types of IDD in California (cerebral palsy, autism, epilepsy, or intellectual disability)?

RQ3: When examining provision of postsecondary education support by the California VR agency between federal fiscal years 2006 and 2016, were there any significant year-to-year differences among the proportions of cases provided with college that were individuals with IDD?

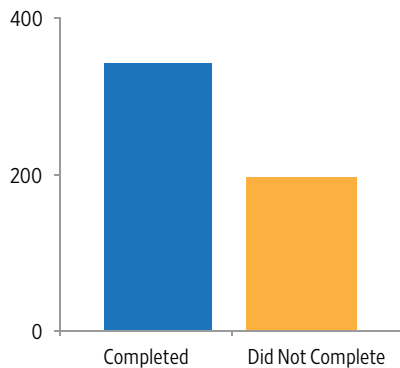
RQ4: For cases closed during federal fiscal year 2014 was there a significant difference between the proportions of individuals with IDD who were provided with college when comparing California to all other state VR agencies combined?

RESULTS

Statistically significant differences were observed for three of the four research questions with key findings indicating increased earnings among those with IDD

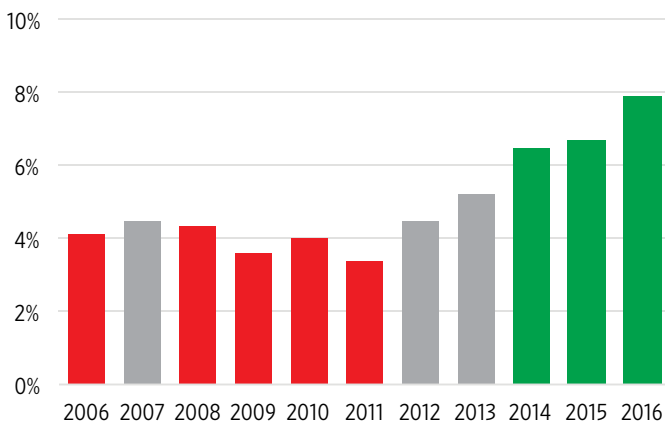
who completed certificates and degrees, year-to-year differences in the provision of postsecondary support to people with IDD in California, and differences in provision of college among individuals with IDD in California compared to all other U.S. states and territories combined.

FIGURE 1: Weekly Earnings at Case Closure in California (postsecondary education completion vs. those who did not complete)



With respect to Research Question 1, a significant difference between the mean weekly earnings of the two groups was observed; individuals who advanced their highest level of education completed to postsecondary certificate or degree completion ($n = 247$) earned more than individuals who did not advance to certificate or degree completion ($n = 8,722$) ($p < .001$; Cohen's $d = 1.02$).

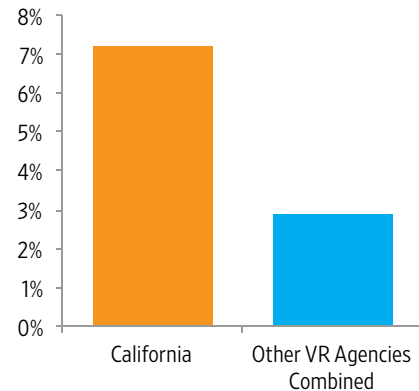
FIGURE 2: Proportions of Individuals Provided with College Support in California



Significant year-to-year differences were observed among the proportions of rehabilitation cases in California provided with postsecondary education that were individuals with IDD in all years but 2007, 2012, and 2013 ($p < .001$). During federal fiscal years 2006, 2008, 2009, 2010 and 2011 the proportions of rehabilitation cases receiving college that were individuals with IDD were significantly lower than the

expected count. During federal fiscal years 2014, 2015, and 2016 the proportions of rehabilitation cases receiving college that were individuals with IDD were significantly higher than the expected count.

FIGURE 3: Nationwide Proportion of Individuals Provided with College Support Compared to California



A significant difference in the proportions of cases with IDD that were provided with postsecondary education was observed between VR cases in California compared to all other VR agencies combined ($p < .001$). In California 7.2% of cases where the individual had a primary cause of impairment of IDD were provided with college training while the equivalent figure for all other VR agencies combined was 2.9%.

CONCLUSION

Although the findings of this study cannot definitively link postsecondary education degree completion to better employment outcomes, they do demonstrate a need for further exploration of the benefits of college and the potential to contribute to higher earnings among individuals with IDD.

IMPLICATIONS FOR PRACTICE

Given that college and university training can be part of Individualized Plan for Employment (IPE) development, rehabilitation counselors can include this as an option for individuals who are interested in jobs that require postsecondary education. This strategy may become a more relevant option as more and more individuals with IDD have goals of attending college.

Given the small proportion of cases of individuals with IDD who received postsecondary education support and advanced to certificate or degree completion, VR agencies should consider the favorable employment outcomes of those who did advance and give thought to expanding local development of education partnership programs that would support more students with IDD as they pursue postsecondary certificates and degrees.

Rehabilitation practitioners and policymakers should monitor the trend reflected in research question three to determine if the observed results reflect the sustained impact of policies and legislation such as the Higher Education Opportunities Act, WIOA, and the California Employment First Policy. State developmental disability entities should consider policy initiatives that expand opportunities to fund postsecondary education and training for individuals with IDD, including the option of blended funding as a means of pooling resources.

Educators in secondary and postsecondary settings should work to facilitate greater collaboration between colleges and universities and public disability-focused entities in order to enhance services and supports provided to students with IDD as they pursue and complete postsecondary studies.

Finally, individuals with IDD, their family members and their advocates should seize opportunities to request support in attending college and universities as legislation and policy is developed around systems collaboration and new approaches designed to support the academic and vocational success of persons with IDD.

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ABOUT THE AUTHORS

STORMY MILLER SABIA, Ed.D. is Director of Student Services at Student Accessibility and Psychological Services, College of Marin.

MARK TUCKER, Ph.D., CRC is Associate Professor, Department of Administration, Rehabilitation & Postsecondary Education at San Diego State University / Interwork Institute.

FOR MORE INFORMATION

Please see this journal article: Miller, S. C., Sax, C. L., & Tucker, M. S. (2019). Examining associations between postsecondary education, earnings, and provision of college and university training related to individuals with intellectual and developmental disabilities served by Vocational Rehabilitation. *Journal of Rehabilitation*, 85(1), 22–34.

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